

Editorial

Please Sign In. Or Else.

T HIS CHRISTMAS WAS the first time I did all my shopping online. Giving the finishing touches to this issue and many trips out of town meant little or no time for the luxury of doing the mall rounds. Add to it the sheer convenience of online... I was through with my purchases in all of 30 minutes. And this included Googling for the best shopping sites, the best deals on offer, choosing the gifts, and the credit card bit.

I happened to have been signed into Google—what they call the “Personalized Home.” It hadn’t occurred to me, though, in those 30 minutes I’d left digital footprints all across the Web—right from my gift preferences to my choice of Web sites to even the amount of time it took me to nail down the gifts. Now e-payments are more or less secure these days and robust systems have lent a great deal of credibility to payments online, but what I’m concerned about is that somewhere on Google’s servers are locked away little titbits about me. Very personal things. Well, they *do* call it “Personalized.”

The sheer dominance of a handful of search engines is my concern here. Especially Google. It is not me who determines whether I get to search all existing sites; it depends on whether Google has decided to index the site. In a very real way, Google controls my Web experience and my online exposure.

Now what if Google were to make it mandatory to sign in before you could use its search services? They’re well within their rights to do it!

Every day we send millions of search queries to Google and give away a daily log of our online preferences. Imagine if Personalized were mandatory. What might they do with all that data? Will they use it to enhance our search experience, or will they limit our search to the sites that pay them?

And then, one day, say Google decides to link search with its other services such as Gmail, Orkut, and Google Earth... they’ll end up knowing our friends, our social interactions, our location. And there’s more—wait till we get habituated to using Google Docs and Spreadsheets! You, just a few gigabytes of data on Google’s servers, locked for posterity!

The scary thing here is that, like I said, there’s nothing to stop them from making Personalized mandatory. We’re so dependant on search, even if



Deepak Ajwani Executive Editor

“In a very real way, Google controls my Web experience”

they did, we’d all take it in our stride—and sign in every time. Google is also offering an online payment service (in the US right now), so, happily, they’ll also have your credit card details. And possibly your mother’s maiden name. And God knows what else.

In a way, it might seem justified: you’re getting so much information without clicking a single ad, so you’ve got to give something in return—right? No, there’s something wrong here.

I do *not* want Them to know I spent six and a half minutes choosing a yellow soft toy for my daughter on the 22nd of December 2006. It might seem insignificant, but I’m just not comfortable.

editor@thinkdigit.com